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AI Collective NIGERIA

Nigeria Artificial Intelligence Industry Collective

NIGERIA AI COLLECTIVE COMMUNITY MONTHLY DIGEST

DEEP LEARNING INDABA 2026 SPECIAL EDITION

Explore the Latest from Our Community: Key Resources, Insights, and Hot Topics in AI

This Month's Highlights:

- Africa's Deep Learning Indaba Comes to Nigeria for the First Time
- Nigeria's Long Journey from Participant to Host
- UNGA 2025 Confirms Nigeria's Hosting Milestone
- 1,271 Participants from 66 Countries Gather in Lagos
- DLI 2026 Through the Five National AI Strategy Pillars
- Nigeria Takes Four Recognitions in Lagos
- Dr Olubayo Adekanmbi Names Five Diseases Holding Back African AI
- Indaba Heads to South Africa in 2027 Under a New Pan-African Ownership Model
- Meta and the Federal Government Launch AI Academy Nigeria
- Nigeria Launches the Pan-African ATLAS Network
- Africa Adopts the Abuja Declaration as Nigeria Takes the ATU Chair
- NITDA Signs Nigeria's Sovereign Cloud Framework
- Senate Hears Bill for a National Artificial Intelligence Academy
- Project BRIDGE Enters Execution
- INTERPOL Links AI to 55% of Cybercrime in Africa
- Nigeria and China Convene on People-Centred AI Governance
- Europe Begins Enforcing AI Act Transparency Rules
- Nvidia Mobilises More Than $500 Billion for AI Compute

Papers

- Full Fine-Tuning vs. Parameter-Efficient Adaptation for Low-Resource African ASR: A Controlled Study with Whisper-Small
- ÒWE-Voice: An Evaluation of Monolingual and Multilingual ASR Models Using a Yoruba Proverb Speech Dataset
- A Multimodal Dataset for Automating Language Vitality and Endangerment Assessment in South-South Nigeria

Opportunities

- Sahara CodeSwitch Africa Challenge
- AI for Good
- SGCI Multilateral Research Call
- Advanced Human Rights Course
- BUILD Conference 2026 – Call for Abstracts

Upcoming Events

- Pan African AI and Innovation Summit 2026
- MCP Developers Summit Nairobi
- AI Expo Africa 2026
- Moonshot by TechCabal 2026
- Africa Tech Festival 2026
- NeurIPS 2026

Thoughtful Leadership

- Dr Olubayo Adekanmbi
- Professor Enase Okonedo
- The Deep Learning Indaba 2026 General Chairs
- Dr. Bosun Tijani
- President Paul Kagame
- Doreen Bogdan-Martin
- Doreen Bogdan-Martin

From Participant to Host: Nigeria's Long Journey to the Indaba

Source: DLI LinkedIn page

Deep Learning Indaba 2026 did not begin in Lagos on 2 August. For Nigeria, it was the visible culmination of years of participation, community-building, research contribution and persistent advocacy to bring Africa's flagship machine-learning gathering home.

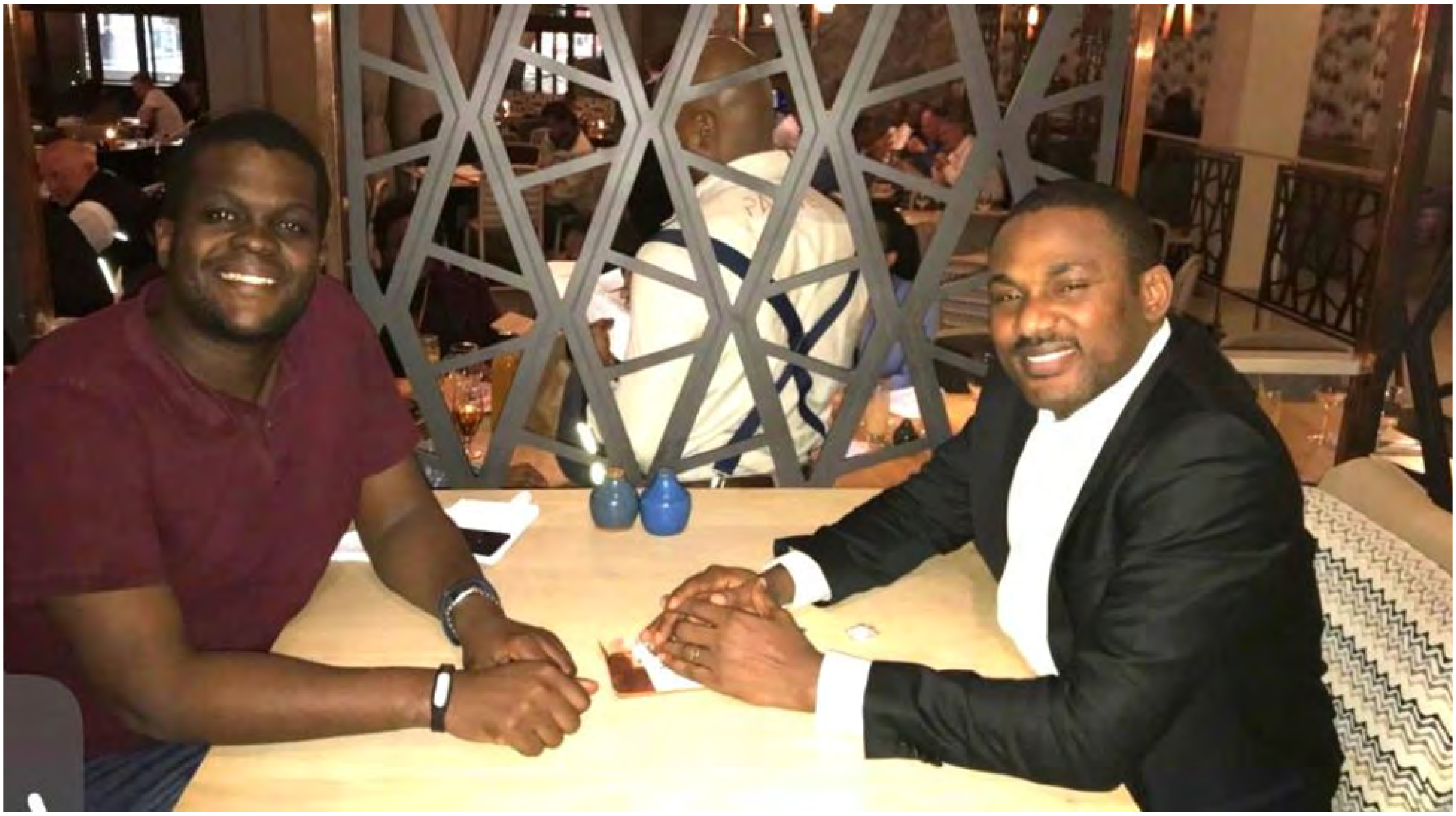
Dr Olubayo Adekanmbi's account of the journey provides an important starting point. In 2018, Nigerian participation was deliberately established within the emerging pan-African community, including early engagement in Cape Town and a subsequent effort to formalise Nigeria and West Africa's participation. By 2019, Nigerian researchers were gaining continental visibility through papers, posters and awards. In 2022, Nigerian representatives were making the case in Tunis that the Indaba should come to Nigeria. In 2023, discussions in London moved that ambition closer to a concrete hosting commitment. The proposal and planning process then gathered momentum through subsequent continental engagements.

The journey matters because it shows that hosting was not a one-off opportunity. Nigeria first had to become a consistent contributor to the community it eventually hosted.

The decisive national milestone came in September 2025. At UNGA 80, the Honourable Minister of Communications, Innovation and Digital Economy, Dr 'Bosun Tijani, officially announced that Nigeria would host Deep Learning Indaba 2026, with Data Science Nigeria serving as the local organising partner. The announcement marked the transition from years of Nigerian participation and advocacy to a confirmed national hosting commitment.

Source: Dr Olubayo Adekanmbi
April 2018 – Cape Town South Africa: Nigeria first formal presence at Indaba via IndabaX

Source: Dr Olubayo Adekanmbi
April 2018 – Cape Town South Africa: Mobilizing Nigerian students in South Africa



Source: Dr Olubayo Adekanmbi

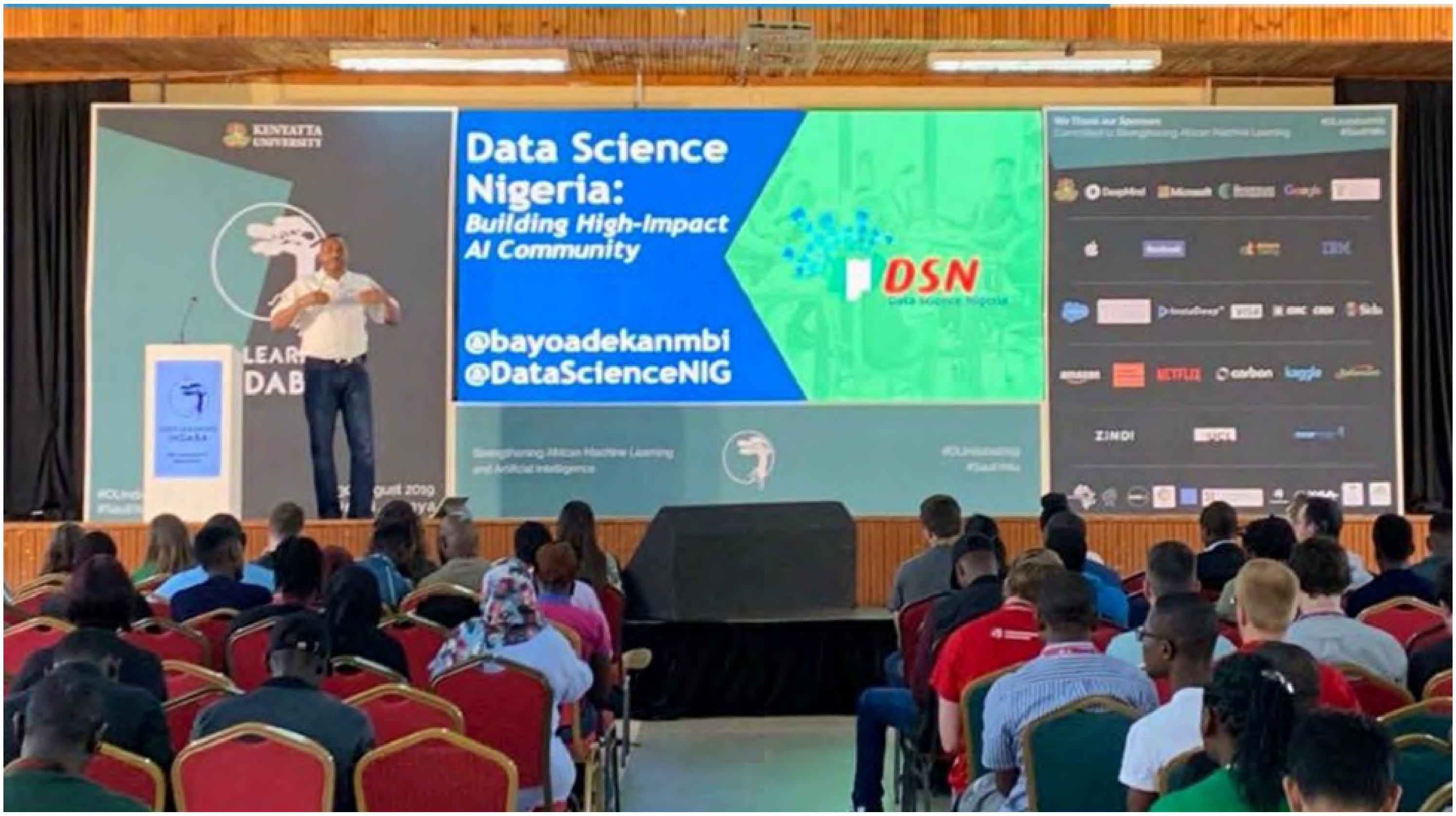
June 2018 – Johannesburg South Africa: Formalizing the deal – South meets West with Prof Vukosi at the iconic Mandela Square

Source: Dr Olubayo Adekanmbi

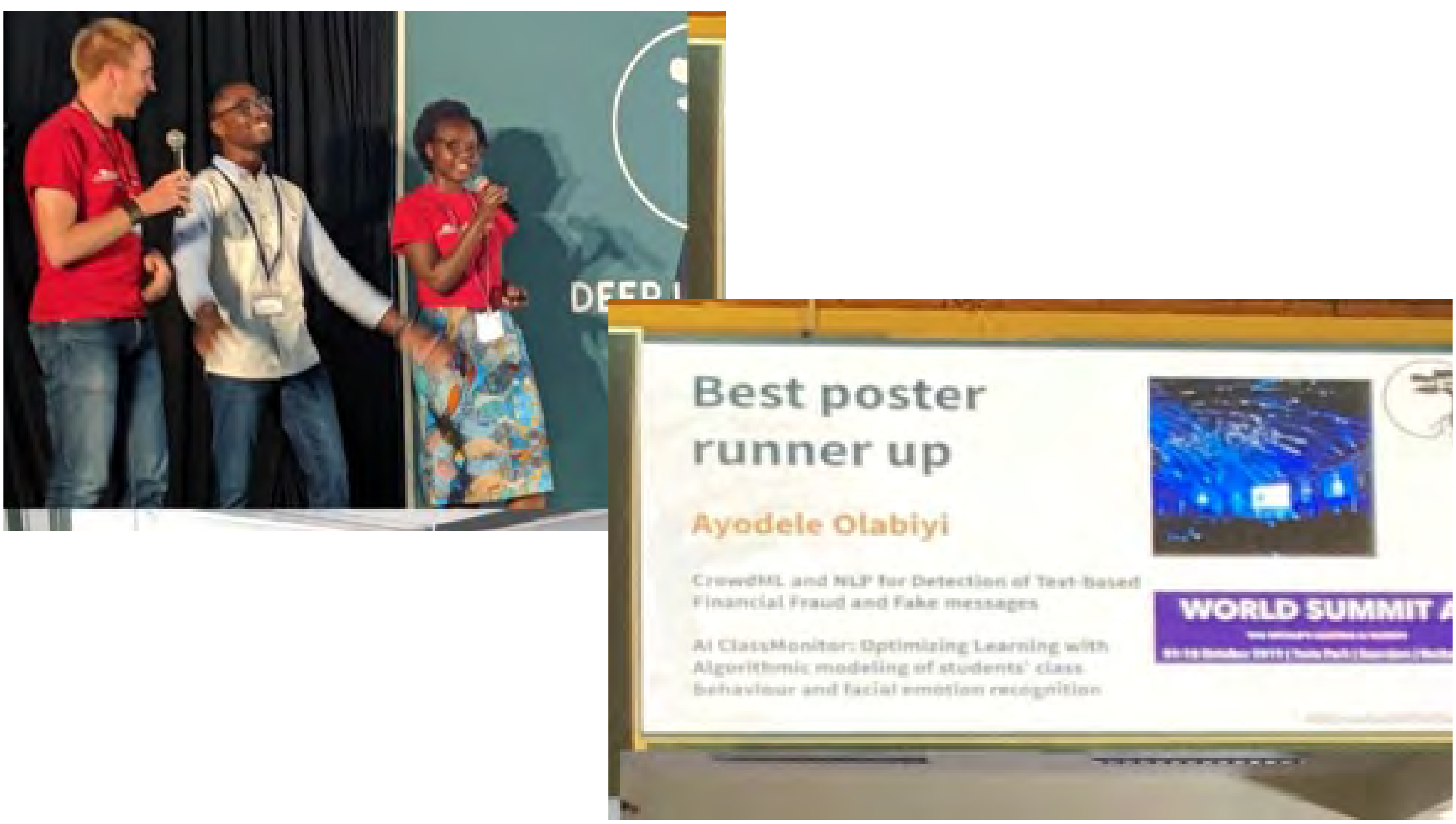
Sept 2018 – Stellenbosch South Africa : Strong Nigerian presence with Data Science Nigeria sponsored participants

Source: Dr Olubayo Adekanmbi
Sept 2019 – Nairobi, Kenya : The Nigeria moment – awards and strong visibility

Source: Dr Olubayo Adekanmbi
Sept 2019 – Nairobi, Kenya : The Nigeria moment – awards and strong visibility



Source: Dr Olubayo Adekanmbi
Sept 2019 – Nairobi, Kenya : The Nigeria moment – awards and strong visibility



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Sept 2019 – Nairobi, Kenya : The Nigeria moment – awards and strong visibility

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Sept 2019 – Nairobi, Kenya : The Nigeria moment – awards and strong visibility

Source: Dr Olubayo Adekanmbi
Sept 2021– London, UK : DSN at 5 in London – pitch to Ulrich Paquet as a potential host

Source: Dr Olubayo Adekanmbi
Sept 2022 – Tunis, Tunisia: The Nigeria Agenda with intentional sponsorship

Source: Dr Olubayo Adekanmbi
Sept 2022 – Tunis, Tunisia : : The Nigeria Agenda with intentional sponsorship and formal request to host

Source: Dr Olubayo Adekanmbi

Sept 2022 – Tunis, Tunisia : : The Nigeria Agenda with intentional sponsorship and formal request to host

Source: Dr Olubayo Adekanmbi

Sept 2023– London: Shakir and Avishkar aligned on the Nigeria's hosting agenda with support of Karim Beguir

Source: Dr Olubayo Adekanmbi
2024– Dakar, Senegal: First engagement meeting with Avishkar and Vukosi to develop a hosting proposal and plan with massive DSN community presence.

Source: Dr Olubayo Adekanmbi
2025– Formal announcement in Kigali, Rwanda with 2 DSN communities winning a crowning awards

Source: DSN LinkedIn page

Source: Data Science Nigeria

2026- Deep Learning Indaba

The Journey at a Glance

- **2017** — Deep Learning Indaba is established as a pan-African community for machine learning and AI.
- **2018** — Nigerian participation grows through engagement with the emerging Indaba community and the devel opment of national/community activity.
- **2019** — Nigerian researchers and community members gain stronger visibility through research, posters and awards.
- **2022** — Nigeria makes a formal push for the Indaba to come to Nigeria, with a strong Nigerian presence and host ing advocacy.
- **2023** — Further discussions in London advance the prospect of Nigeria hosting.
- **2024–2025** — Nigerian community-building and IndabaX activity continue, strengthening the ecosystem and the hosting case.
- **September 2025** — At UNGA 80, Honourable Minister Dr 'Bosun Tijani officially announces Nigeria as host of DLI 2026; Data Science Nigeria is named local organising partner.
- **2–7 August 2026** — Pan-Atlantic University, Lagos hosts the eighth Deep Learning Indaba.

Deep Learning Indaba 2026: Africa's Flagship AI Gathering Lands in Lagos

From 2nd to 7th August 2026, Pan-Atlantic University in Lagos hosted the eighth Deep Learning Indaba, bringing the continent's machine-learning and AI community to Nigeria for the first time. The edition was framed around sovereign intelligence and African scale: Africa's capacity to build, steward and understand its own systems, data and scientific direction.

The official DLI materials describe the gathering as a collective commitment to placing African talent at the centre of AI creation. For the Nigeria AI Collective, the composition of the hosting team is significant: Pan-Atlantic University, a core Collective partner through Lagos Business School, and Data Science Nigeria, another core partner, were central to bringing the gathering to Nigeria

Indaba 2026 in Numbers

- 2,903 applications received, against 533 guests invited.
- 1,271 total participants: 855 attended in person and 416 joined virtually.
- 66 countries represented, based on the nationalities of 1,199 participants.
- 60% of 884 participants who provided an application category were students.
- More than 1,000 individual forms of financial support were extended across travel, accommodation and registration.
- 718 participants named 183 distinct AI and data-science communities.
- Data Science Nigeria was cited by 146 respondents (20%), making it the most-cited national community in the reported community-membership data.

These figures matter because they turn ecosystem-building from an abstract claim into something measurable. The scale of student participation, financial support and community affiliation shows that DLI was not simply a showcase for established researchers; it was a mechanism for widening access to Africa's AI research community.

FROM THE INDABA TO THE NATIONAL AGENDA

Deep Learning Indaba 2026 was more than a major AI gathering on Nigerian soil. For the Nigeria AI Collective, it offered something more valuable: a live view of what Africa's AI ecosystem is building, where its challenges remain, and how those realities connect to Nigeria's National Artificial Intelligence Strategy.

The programme brought together conversations spanning compute, research, talent, language technologies, data, AI safety, applications, startups, intellectual property and digital public infrastructure. Viewed through the five pillars of the National AI Strategy, these were not disconnected conference sessions. They were pieces of the same national question:

What does it take for Nigeria to build an AI ecosystem that is capable, inclusive, responsible and globally competitive?

Building Foundational AI Infrastructure.

- Building Foundational AI Infrastructure
- Building Faster Transformers with Triton: A Hands-On Introduction to GPU Kernel Programming
- Building On Device AI Applications Using Gemma 3n

Building and Sustaining a World-Class AI Ecosystem.

- Doing ML Research from the Margins
- Mastering the Scientific Narrative: A Practical Guide to Reading and Writing High-Impact AI Research Papers

Accelerating AI Adoption and Sector Transformation.

- GeoAI for a Climate-Resilient Africa
- Data Science for Health in Africa
- Sovereign Supply Chains: Frontier AI for Resilient African Logistics
- AI on Digital Public Infrastructure: Building Inclusive and Impact-Driven Public Intelligence Systems in Emerging Economies

Developing a Robust AI Governance Framework

- Navigating the Intellectual Property Frontier of African AI
- DIGITAfrica AI/ML and Connectivity Blueprints for a Pan-African Research Infrastructure in Digital Sciences
- Beyond Benchmarks: Scaling Multi-Turn Participatory AI Evaluations in Health and Education

Ensuring Responsible and Ethical AI Development and Deployment

- Building Red-Teaming Capacity for AI Safety Evaluation in African Context
- Understanding Model Alignment: Concepts and Practical Steps
- Fair, Trustworthy, and Context-Aware Machine Learning for Africa
- Adversarial Thinking in AI Systems

THE COMPUTE QUESTION: CAN AFRICA BUILD WHAT IT NEEDS?

For African AI researchers, the compute challenge is not an abstract conversation. Access to sufficiently powerful and affordable infrastructure can determine what researchers are able to experiment with, what models they can train and how far an idea can go beyond a notebook.

DLI 2026 put that reality on the programme.

The tutorial **"Beyond the Notebook: Mastering Cloud GPU Infrastructure for Scalable African AI"** took participants from the familiar notebook environment into the practical world of cloud GPU infrastructure. The session explored African-hosted GPU environments, persistent computing, large data pipelines, custom CUDA configurations, fine-tuning and other workloads that become important when AI moves from experimentation towards scale.
The conversation went deeper in "Building Faster Transformers with Triton: A Hands-On Introduction to GPU Kernel **Programming**", where participants explored how GPU hardware can be used more efficiently for modern AI workloads.

Then, from another direction, **"Building On Device AI Applications Using Gemma 3n"** demonstrated that the infrastructure question does not always have to end with larger cloud systems. Running capable AI directly on devices can reduce dependence on constant cloud connectivity and bring intelligence closer to the end user.

Taken together, these sessions made an important point: **AI infrastructure is not simply about acquiring more GPUs. It is about having the capability to access, optimise and deploy compute in ways that make AI development practical and sustainable.**

That conversation sits squarely within **Pillar 1 of Nigeria's National AI Strategy: Building Foundational AI Infrastructure.**

For Nigeria, it also connects directly to work already underway through the Nigeria AI Collective, including efforts led by Data Science Nigeria to expand access to GPU compute for researchers, communities, and innovators.

The bigger picture: DLI showed what infrastructure sovereignty looks like when it moves from policy language into practical skills, tools and access.

THE PEOPLE BEHIND THE MODELS: BUILDING A WORLD-CLASS AI COMMUNITY

Infrastructure alone does not create an AI ecosystem. The machines need people who can use them, question them, improve them and turn research into solutions.

That human infrastructure was visible throughout DLI.

In **"Doing ML Research from the Margins"**, researchers explored how meaningful machine-learning research can be pursued even when access to institutional resources, mentorship and compute is limited. The session addressed practical questions around identifying research problems, working within constraints and building pathways towards publication and collaboration.

Another tutorial, **"Mastering the Scientific Narrative: A Practical Guide to Reading and Writing High-Impact AI Research Papers,"** addressed a different but equally important capability: helping researchers communicate their work effectively and participate more confidently in the global research community.
These interventions matter because Africa's AI ambitions ultimately depend on the people capable of carrying them forward.

DLI's own participation profile reinforced this. Students represented a significant share of the delegates, while financial support helped widen participation across the continent. Nigerian students and early-career researchers were therefore not simply spectators at an international conference; they were participating in the same research, technical and community conversations shaping the future of AI.

This speaks directly to **Pillar 2 of the National AI Strategy: Building and Sustaining a World-Class AI Ecosystem**.
The strategic question for Nigeria is no longer simply how many people are interested in AI. It is whether those people can find the training, mentorship, research opportunities, infrastructure and communities needed to turn interest into expertise.
The bigger picture: DLI made the AI talent pipeline visible, from students entering the field to researchers developing expertise and communities creating pathways for the next generation.

WHEN AI MEETS AFRICA'S REAL PROBLEMS

The strongest case for AI is rarely the technology itself. It is what that technology can change.
DLI's programme repeatedly brought AI back to African development challenges.

The workshop "**GeoAI for a Climate-Resilient Africa**" explored the use of geospatial AI in responding to climate and environmental challenges. "**Data Science for Health in Africa"** connected data-driven methods to health challenges across the continent, while **"Sovereign Supply Chains: Frontier AI for Resilient African Logistics"** examined how advanced AI could contribute to more resilient logistics systems.

The conversation extended into the public sector through "AI on Digital Public Infrastructure: Building Inclusive and Impact-Driven Public Intelligence Systems in Emerging Economies." Here, AI was considered alongside digital public infrastructure, multilingual systems, voice technologies and public intelligence.
These sessions illustrate a crucial principle behind **Pillar 3 of Nigeria's National AI Strategy: Accelerating AI Adoption and Sector Transformation.**

Nigeria does not need to adopt AI simply because AI exists. The strategic opportunity is to identify where AI can improve healthcare, agriculture, climate resilience, logistics, education, public services and other areas of national importance, and then build the infrastructure and institutional capacity required to deploy it responsibly.

The bigger picture: DLI shifted the conversation from "What can the latest AI model do?" towards the more useful question: "What problems can AI help Africa solve?"

CAN WE TRUST WHAT WE BUILD?

As AI systems become more capable, another question becomes unavoidable:
How do we know they are safe, reliable and appropriate for the people and environments in which they are deployed?
DLI did not leave that question to policy discussions alone.

The workshop "**Building Red-Teaming Capacity for AI Safety Evaluation in African Contexts**" gave participants practical exposure to evaluating AI systems for safety in African contexts.
In "Understanding Model Alignment: Concepts and Practical Steps," participants explored how AI systems can be aligned with human preferences and values, including considerations around culturally diverse values and low-resource languages.

The programme also featured **"Responsible and Sovereign AI: Fair, Trustworthy, and Context-Aware Machine Learning for Africa,"** which examined fairness, transparency, robustness and accountability in African settings.
Meanwhile, the TrustAI workshop questioned the reliability of using LLMs themselves as judges for AI systems, while **"Adversarial Thinking in AI Systems"** explored real-world model vulnerabilities and approaches to improving resilience.
These were practical expressions of **Pillar 4 of the National AI Strategy: Ensuring Responsible and Ethical AI Development and Deployment.**

The significance is important. Responsible AI cannot simply mean publishing an ethics statement after a system has been built. It requires people who know how to test models, identify weaknesses, evaluate risks and understand how AI behaves in specific social and cultural contexts.

The bigger picture: DLI demonstrated that responsible AI capability has to grow alongside AI capability itself.

THE RULES BEHIND THE REVOLUTION

Technology develops quickly. Institutions and rules have to catch up.
Several DLI sessions showed why AI governance cannot be separated from the technical ecosystem.

The workshop **"Navigating the Intellectual Property Frontier of African AI"** examined the increasingly important relationship between AI development and intellectual property, including the questions that arise when African researchers and companies create datasets, models, software and other AI assets.
"Building Africa's Digital Future: DIGITAfrica AI/ML and Connectivity Blueprints for a Pan-African Research Infrastructure in Digital Sciences" connected AI development to the wider digital infrastructure required to support African research.

Another programme strand examined the relationship between AI, online polarisation and the weaponisation of social media, bringing the conversation into information integrity and broader societal risk.
The session **"Beyond Benchmarks: Scaling Multi-Turn Participatory AI Evaluations in Health and Education"** added an important human dimension: evaluating AI systems through the experiences and needs of the communities expected to use them, rather than relying solely on technical benchmarks.
Together, these conversations speak to **Pillar 5 of the National AI Strategy: Developing a Robust AI Governance Framework.**
They reinforce a central point for Nigeria: effective AI governance is not only about regulation. It also involves **intellectual property, evaluation, accountability, digital infrastructure, information integrity and institutions capable of responding to rapidly changing technology.**
The bigger picture: The rules surrounding AI are becoming part of the infrastructure of AI itself.

THE LANGUAGE QUESTION THAT CUTS ACROSS EVERYTHING

One theme at DLI was too important to confine to a single National AI Strategy pillar: **African language AI**.

The workshop **"Cultivating Sovereign African NLP"** placed African languages at the centre of the conversation about who gets represented in AI systems and whose languages are supported by them.
The "**Data, Culture, and Community"** session around the AfricaNLP Playbook and Annotation Tool connected language technology with the people and communities responsible for creating and validating the data behind these systems.

This is more than an NLP problem.
Language touches infrastructure, because models require compute and data. It touches ecosystem development, because researchers and communities must create the datasets and expertise required to build local systems. It touches AI adoption, because useful local-language systems can support citizens and businesses. It touches responsible AI, because cultural and linguistic context can influence how models behave. And it touches governance, because questions of consent, ownership, representation and data stewardship cannot be ignored.

For Nigeria, a country with enormous linguistic diversity and an expanding role in African language AI, this is particularly relevant.
African language AI is therefore one of the clearest examples of sovereign intelligence becoming practical.

FROM FIVE PILLARS TO ONE NATIONAL QUESTION

Seen from the Nigeria AI Collective's perspective, DLI 2026 brought the five pillars of the National AI Strategy into the same physical space.

Compute enables research.
Research develops talent.
Talent builds applications.
Applications create new governance questions.
Governance creates the conditions for responsible scale.

And running through all of them is the question of whether Africa can build AI that reflects African realities.
That is why DLI's arrival in Nigeria matters beyond the event itself.
The significance is not simply that thousands of people came to Lagos, or that Nigeria hosted one of the continent's largest AI research gatherings. The deeper significance is that, for one week, many of the capabilities Nigeria's AI strategy seeks to develop were visible, connected and being actively practised on Nigerian soil.

For the Nigeria AI Collective, that is the story worth documenting.

DLI 2026 did not write Nigeria's AI strategy. It gave us a rare opportunity to see parts of that strategy coming alive — in compute rooms, research sessions, language workshops, safety discussions, startup conversations, datasets, classrooms and communities.

The question now is what Nigeria chooses to make permanent?


Building Responsible

Data Science Nigeria Across the Programme

Data Science Nigeria contributed across the programme rather than appearing only as a local host. Dr Olubayo Adekanmbi opened the GeoAI for a Climate-Resilient Africa workshop with a keynote on building inclusive AI ecosystems for climate and sustainable development.
DSN also convened the digital public infrastructure workshop with the Nigeria AI Scaling Hub. Dr Ife Adebara contributed to discussions on sustainable compute and faculty development, while the wider DSN ecosystem was represented across research, skills and community activities.

For the Collective, this matters because partner activity at DLI provides examples of how national strategy can be implemented through real programmes: climate applications, public intelligence systems, compute access, language technology and talent development.


f. Olayinka David-West
Lagos Business School
tlantic University


DSN


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Nigeria's recognition at DLI 2026 provides another form of evidence that local research is increasingly contributing to continental AI capability.

- Akinbobola Adegboyega of Olabisi Onabanjo University received the Grace Alele-Williams Masters Award for research introducing "affective fidelity" as an evaluation lens for machine translation in low-resource Yorùbá.
- Professor Sakinat Folorunso of Olabisi Onabanjo University received the Umuntu Award for outstanding service to the African machine-learning community.
- Nnamdi Isichei of Miva Open University was named runner-up in his poster competition category for work characterising the Nigerian Exchange for machine-learning-based portfolio research.
- Haleem Opeyemi Akintayo of the Olabisi Onabanjo University DSN chapter took first runner-up in the Live Market Prediction Challenge.

The significance is not the medal count. It is that Nigerian researchers and students are producing work that is both globally visible and grounded in Nigerian problems and contexts.


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ALELE-WILLIAMS
Masters Award
2026
Akinbobola
Adegboyega


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Lagos, Nigeria
2nd - 7th August,
2026
#Indaba2026
#DLI2026
#ImiWa
Award Winners
Akinbobola Adegboyega
Dr Everlyn Chimoto
Dr Hellina Hailu Nigatu

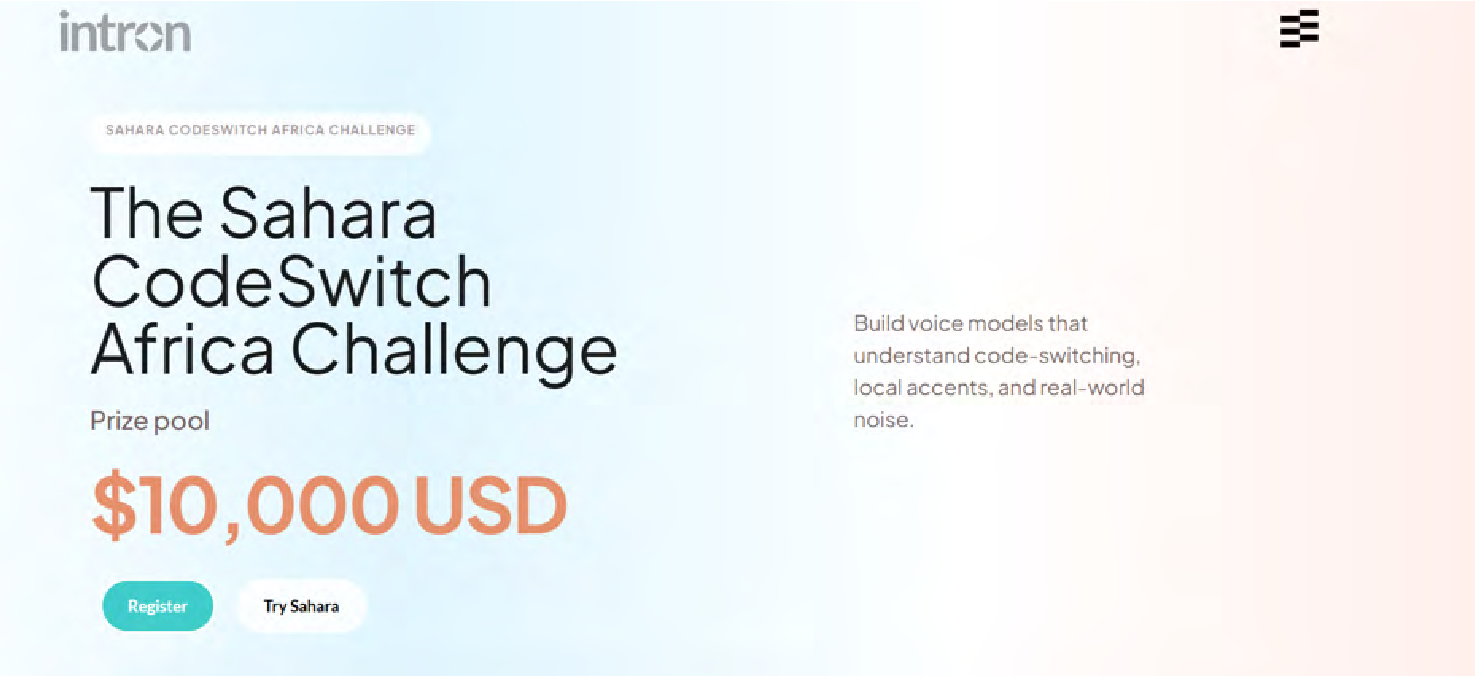

DEEP

Government, Regulators and the Lagos Ecosystem in the Room

Nigeria's Minister of Communications, Innovation and Digital Economy, Dr 'Bosun Tijani, attended and addressed delegates on the role of technology, research and innovation in Africa's digital transformation. Olatunbosun Alake, Lagos State Commissioner for Science and Technology, represented the state government, and Professor Enase Okonedo spoke for the host institution.

The presence of both federal and state officials at a research conference — rather than a trade expo — is itself a shift worth noting, and one the Collective has argued for consistently.

From Debate to Build: the Sahara CodeSwitch Africa Challenge



The most concrete build-oriented output of the week was the Sahara CodeSwitch Africa Challenge, launched at DLI by Nigerian-founded voice-AI company Intron. The challenge targets code-switching — the everyday mixing of English with Yorùbá, Hausa, Igbo or Pidgin — which remains a persistent failure point for speech systems deployed in Africa.

The challenge opened with 97 teams from 19 countries. Intron also released public resources around the Sahara speech API, AfriSwitch benchmark and AfriSwitchCare medical code-switching dataset.
This is an example of the kind of transition the Collective should continue to look for: a research problem becomes a benchmark, the benchmark becomes a developer challenge, and the resulting ecosystem can produce deployable applications.

Access the Challenge here: [Challenge page](#)

The Closing Ceremony: Five Diseases and a Charge

Dr Olubayo Adekanmbi's closing remarks deliberately resisted the easy language of celebration. He named five "dis-eases" holding back African AI ecosystems: Attendiasis, Sponsoriasis, Posteriosis, Communitydemia and Profilitis.

- **Attendiasis** — repeatedly attending major events without building the local communities that sustain the work.
- **Sponsoriasis** — repeated access for the same sponsored participants while newcomers remain excluded.
- **Posteriosis** — producing visible research outputs without sufficient attention to rigorous, real-world impact.
- **Communitydemia** — building communities primarily for personal visibility and abandoning them when per sonal opportunities change.
- **Profilitis** — building impressive individual profiles without returning meaningful value to the African AI eco system.

His challenge was to move beyond superficial wins and commit properly to building sovereign intelligence. For the Nigeria AI Collective, the critique is useful as a standard: are programmes creating talent, knowledge, opportunities and solutions that continue to exist after the event ends?

5 DISEASES HOLDING BACK AFRICA AI ECOSYSTEM

equalyzAI

Dr. Bayo's bold charge at Indaba 2026

1 ATTENDIASIS:

Showing up for every main Indaba while remaining inactive in local IndabaX chapters back home.

2 SPONSORIASIS:

The same faces who seemed to have understood the "system" to securing sponsored attendance to DLI year after year, thereby denying many new persons the opportunity to participate.

3 POSTERIOSIS:

Producing posters mainly for instant big event visibility instead of pursuing rigorous research, grounded with real impact.

4 COMMUNITYDEMIA:

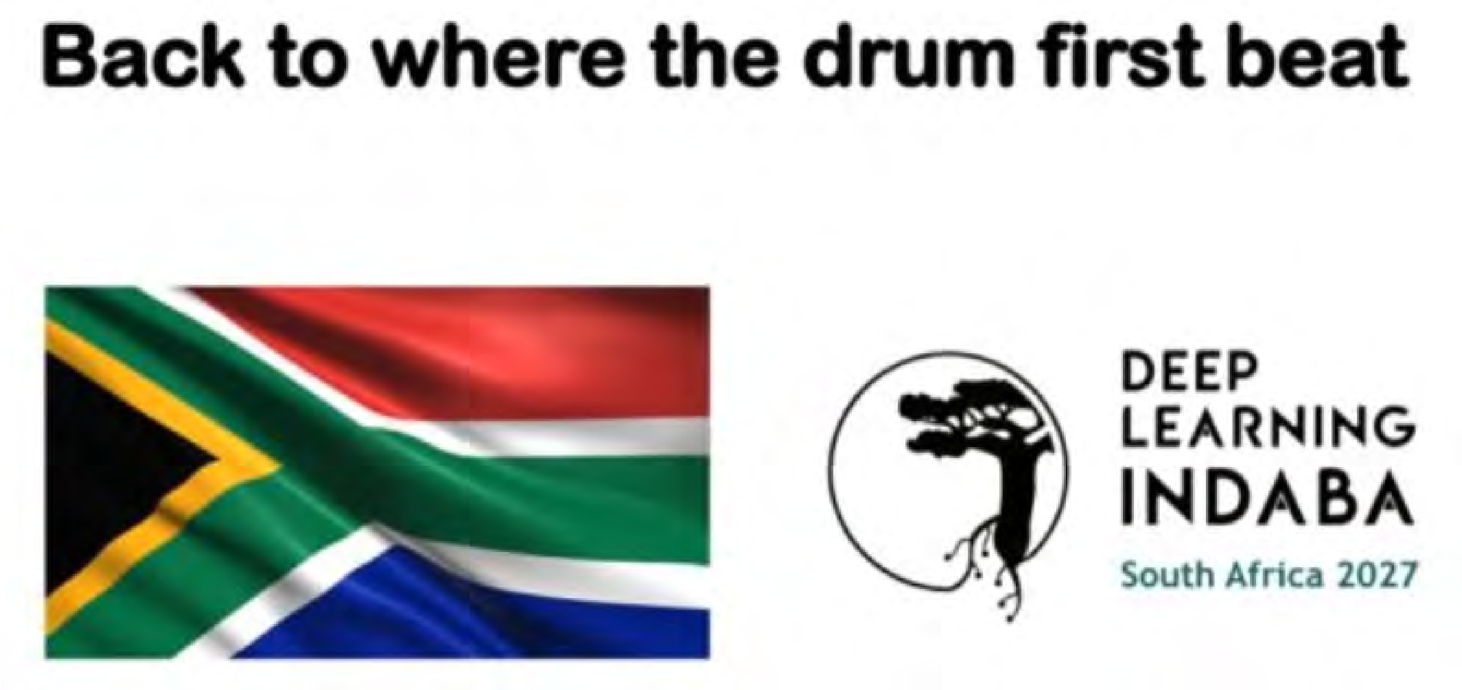
Building a community just to boost a personal brand, only to abandon it once a PhD or fellowship comes through.

5 PROFILITIS:

Curating an impressive global profile without pouring genuine value back into the African AI space.

DON'T STOP UNTIL YOU'RE PROUD

Passing the Mantle: South Africa 2027 and a New Ownership Model



The closing ceremony also marked a transition. The 2027 Indaba will return to South Africa, where the movement began, while the organisation moves towards a broader Pan-African ownership model.

For Nigeria, the end of hosting is therefore not the end of the story. Nigeria has crossed an important threshold: from participant to contributor, advocate and host. The next test is whether the relationships, research, talent and ideas developed around the event translate into sustained national and continental capacity.

What the Indaba Leaves Behind

For the Nigerian ecosystem, the value of hosting is less about the week itself than about what it makes ordinary. Hundreds of Nigerian master's and doctoral students attended a continental research conference without a visa application; 416 more joined remotely through the Gatherly virtual platform.

Nigerian companies sponsored it. A Nigerian university ran it. Nigerian researchers taught on it, judged its posters and won its awards. Sixty per cent of delegates were students — which means the Indaba functioned less as a showcase for established researchers than as an on-ramp for the next generation, on Nigerian soil. Those are durable changes in expectation, and they are the raw material of the sovereign intelligence the theme described.

Meta and the Federal Government Launch AI Academy Nigeria

On 17th of August 2026, Meta and the Federal Ministry of Communications, Innovation and Digital Economy launched AI Academy Nigeria, a training and startup-support programme delivered with the 3 Million Technical Talent programme (3MTT), the National Centre for Artificial Intelligence and Robotics, and Robotics and Artificial Intelligence Nigeria. It runs along three tracks: an AI skills strand offering free courses through Coursera, DeepLearning.AI and DataCamp, open to the wider 3MTT community; a developer bootcamp delivered by RAIN; and a startup pitchathon for early-stage Nigerian companies building with Meta's AI tools.

The two winning startups each receive $5,000 in equity-free funding plus $2,000 in Meta advertising credits, with further advertising credits reported for the strongest performers on the skills track. Applications closed on 21st of August, the pitch final takes place at GITEX Nigeria in Lagos on 3rd of September 2026, and winners travel to Meta's AI Summit in Istanbul on 23rd–24th, November, 2026.

Dr 'Bosun Tijani framed the partnership as "equipping developers, entrepreneurs, and young professionals with practical AI skills while creating pathways for innovation and globally competitive startups". Sade Dada, Meta's Head of Public Policy for Anglophone West Africa, put the diagnosis more plainly: "Nigeria is home to some of Africa's most dynamic AI talent. What many founders and developers need is greater access to practical training, funding and platforms to build impactful solutions." The sums involved are modest; the significance is the routing, a global platform plugging directly into Nigeria's existing national talent pipeline rather than building a parallel one.

Nigeria Launches Pan-African ATLAS Network to Build AI for African Languages

On 23 July 2026, Dr 'Bosun Tijani launched the ATLAS Network at the 7th Ordinary Session of the African Telecommunications Union Conference of Plenipotentiaries in Abuja. The initiative takes Nigeria's national N-ATLAS programme — the Nigerian Atlas for Languages and AI at Scale, and extends it continent-wide, convening governments, universities, researchers and startups to build large language models that reflect African languages and knowledge systems.

The case for it is stark. Africa is home to roughly a third of the world's languages, yet fewer than two per cent are meaningfully supported by modern AI systems. Vice President Kashim Shettima was listed as special guest, represented by Deputy Chief of Staff Senator Ibrahim Hadejia. Coming a fortnight before the Indaba convened in Lagos under a sovereignty theme, the launch positions Nigeria not merely as a participant in African language AI but as its convenor — and turns a domestic programme into an export.

Africa Adopts the Abuja Declaration as Nigeria Takes the ATU Chair

The African Telecommunications Union Conference of Plenipotentiaries ran in Abuja from 23rd to 25th July 2026 and closed with member states adopting the 2026 Abuja Declaration on Meaningful Connectivity. The declaration commits signatories to technology-neutral regulation, improved spectrum access, infrastructure sharing, affordable smartphones and data, digital literacy and cybersecurity, with explicit attention to women, girls, young people and persons with disabilities.

Nigeria assumed the Conference Chairmanship from Algeria. Delegates also elected Zambia's Engineer Kezias Kazuba Mwale as ATU Secretary-General for 2027–2030, taking office on 1st January 2027, and elected 25 member states to the Administrative Council. The practical significance for the AI community is indirect but real: the ATU coordinates African positions feeding into ITU processes, and Nigeria now chairs the body that shapes the spectrum and connectivity rules on which every AI deployment ultimately depends.

NITDA Signs Sovereign Cloud Framework to Anchor AI and Data-Centre Investment

In early August 2026, NITDA Director-General Kashifu Inuwa Abdullahi signed a package of instruments under the National Sovereign Cloud Initiative: the National Cloud Computing Guideline, the National Cloud Technical Guideline and the National Digital Infrastructure Assurance Framework, alongside the presentation of a National Cloud Investment Strategy. A Sovereign Cloud Governance Committee was established for oversight, and the agency said the National Digital Regulatory Platform would be operational by October 2026.

Mr Abdullahi described cloud infrastructure as "a strategic national asset that supports digital government, financial services, artificial intelligence, digital public infrastructure, innovation and digital trade", and cited more than $3 billion in cybercrime costs to Nigeria between 2019 and 2025 as part of the case for domestic assurance standards. No corporate partners were named. For anyone planning local hosting, a hyperscaler agreement or a regulated AI workload, this is the rulebook that will determine where Nigerian data and models can legally sit.

Senate Hears Bill for a National Artificial Intelligence Academy

Senate Hears Bill for a National Artificial Intelligence Academy

On 23rd and 24th July 2026, the Senate Committee on ICT and Cyber Security held a public hearing on two digital sovereignty bills. The first, sponsored by Senator Yemi Adaramodu of Ekiti South, would establish a National Artificial Intelligence Academy at Omuo-Ekiti in Ekiti State, conceived as a national hub for AI research, innovation, skills development and technology transfer. The second, from Senator Ned Nwoko of Delta North, would require global social media and technology platforms to establish physical offices in Nigeria.

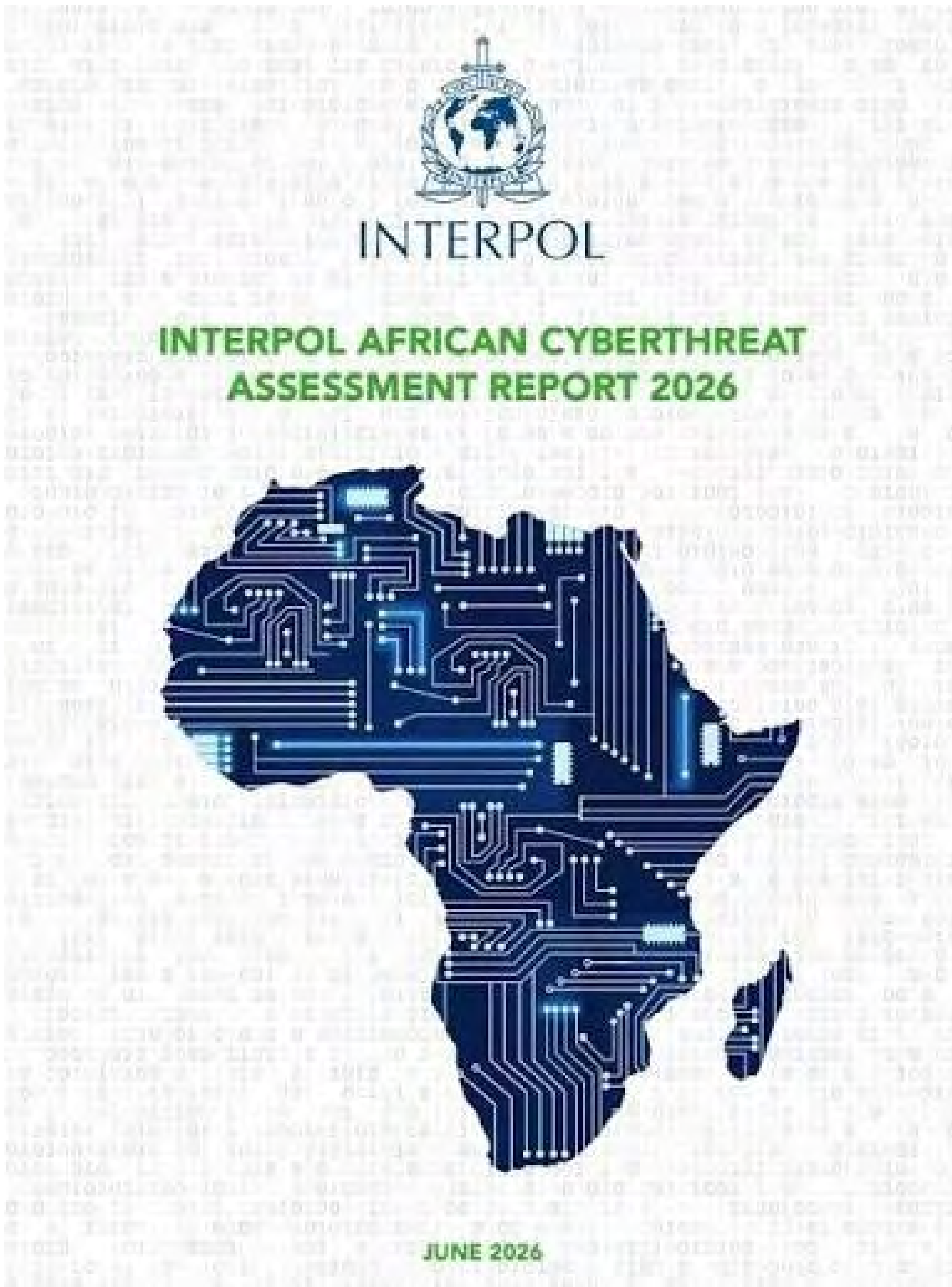
Senator Nwoko told the hearing that his bill “is neither punitive nor hostile to innovation”. Both bills remain at hearing stage and neither has passed. Even so, the AI Academy bill is the first concrete legislative vehicle for a dedicated national AI institution, and worth tracking against the more comprehensive AI legislation the ecosystem has been anticipating.

Project BRIDGE Enters Execution as Bridge OA Is Incorporated

In mid-August 2026 the Federal Government incorporated Bridge Open Access, the special-purpose vehicle that will deliver Project BRIDGE's roughly 90,000-kilometre national fibre backbone across all 774 local government areas. Under the public-private structure, private investors hold at least 51 per cent, with the Federal Government retaining a minority stake. Backers include the World Bank, which committed $500 million in January 2025, alongside the African Development Bank and the European Bank for Reconstruction and Development; the project was originally unveiled in 2024 at an estimated $2 billion.

Dr Tijani called the incorporation "a major milestone". Analysts continue to caution that last-mile connectivity, rather than backbone capacity, remains the binding constraint on Nigerian internet quality. For the AI community the read-across is direct: the data-centre build-out reported in recent months only pays off if fibre reaches the users and institutions those facilities are meant to serve.

INTERPOL: AI Now Linked to 55% of Cybercrime in Africa



INTERPOL published its African Cyberthreat Assessment Report 2026 on 3 August 2026, drawing on a survey of 36 African member countries. It found artificial intelligence linked to 55 per cent of reported cybercrime across the continent, with reported financial losses more than doubling from $192 million in 2024 to $484 million in 2025. Seventy-two per cent of surveyed countries reported scam centres operating on their territory, and more than 600,000 sextortion detections were recorded. Four coordinated operations produced over 1,500 arrests and recovered more than $100 million.

Neal Jetton, Director of INTERPOL's Cybercrime Directorate, said: "AI is automating every stage of a cyberattack from reconnaissance and phishing to extortion and evasion." For Nigerian regulators, banks and platform operators, the report supplies hard, citable evidence that AI-enabled harm in Africa is already operational rather than speculative — and strengthens the case for the assurance and red-teaming capacity discussed at the Indaba.

Nigeria and China Convene on People-Centred AI Governance

The Third Lagos Forum, themed "A People-Centred Approach to AI Governance: Nigeria–China Cooperation to Bridge the Divide", was held on 6 August 2026, convened by the Chinese Consulate General in Lagos, the Nigerian Institute of International Affairs and the Institute of African Studies at Zhejiang Normal University. Chinese Consul General Yan Yuqing confirmed that China will provide 5,000 AI training and seminar opportunities to developing countries over five years, named Nigeria, South Africa, Kenya and Egypt as Africa's key AI engines, and outlined plans for AI application cooperation centres with the African Union covering smart agriculture, healthcare and education.

Professor Eghosa Osaghae, Director-General of the NIIA, represented by Professor Femi Otubanjo, put the domestic stake plainly: "We missed the second industrial revolution... are we going to remain consumers?" With Nigeria simultaneously deepening ties to Western funders and platforms, the forum is a reminder that AI capacity-building now carries geopolitical weight, and that partner selection is becoming a policy choice rather than a procurement one.

Federal Government Opens $110 Million iDICE Debt Window for Tech and Creative Startups

On 28 July 2026 the Federal Government, through the Bank of Industry, opened two debt financing facilities totalling $110 million under iDICE, the Investment in Digital and Creative Enterprises programme co-financed by the African Development Bank, Agence Française de Développement and the Islamic Development Bank. The BOI-iDICE Debt Fund offers $45 million, with ticket sizes from ₦10 million to ₦1 billion, interest capped at 10 per cent per annum and tenors of up to five years with a six-month moratorium. The IsDB-iDICE Debt Fund offers a further $65 million structured as Murabaha asset financing and open to all Nigerians regardless of faith.

Applications run through the Bank of Industry's iDICE portal and cover all 36 states and the Federal Capital Territory. The facilities are not AI-specific, but non-dilutive capital priced below inflation is rare for Nigerian technology founders, and directly relevant to any team financing GPUs, edge hardware or data-collection operations.

Europe Begins Enforcing the AI Act's Transparency Rules

On 2 August 2026 the European Commission's AI Office, working with national authorities, began enforcing the EU AI Act, and the Article 50 transparency obligations took effect. Four requirements now apply: systems that interact directly with people must disclose that they are AI; generators of synthetic media must embed machine-readable markings and provide detection mechanisms; emotion-recognition and biometric categorisation systems must notify users; and deepfakes and AI-generated public-interest content must be disclosed as artificial. Non-compliance carries fines of up to €15 million or three per cent of worldwide annual turnover, whichever is higher.

A transitional period runs to 2 December 2026 for marking and detection obligations on generative systems already on the market, while high-risk system rules have moved to December 2027. Any Nigerian firm serving European users is now in scope. More broadly, Article 50 is the most mature labelling regime in force anywhere, and the most likely template for the disclosure provisions of Nigeria's own eventual AI legislation.

Nvidia Enlists Wall Street to Mobilise Over $500 Billion for AI Compute

On 10 August 2026 Nvidia announced partnerships with Apollo, BlackRock, Blackstone, Brookfield, Goldman Sachs and KKR to establish independent AI compute infrastructure financing platforms, intended to mobilise more than $500 billion of third-party capital for Nvidia customers including frontier AI labs, enterprises and AI cloud providers. Chief executive Jensen Huang framed the rationale bluntly: "In AI, compute is revenue. NVIDIA compute is uniquely suited for this role." Apollo President Jim Zelter described modern compute as "a scarce, mission-critical asset class with compelling investment characteristics". The arrangements remain subject to final agreement execution.

The signal for Nigeria is that compute is being financialised as an asset class in its own right. Nigerian data-centre and AI-factory projects will increasingly be assessed by the same institutional investors, against the same return expectations, as facilities in Texas or Abu Dhabi, which raises the bar on power reliability, offtake contracts and bankable structuring.

OpenAI Completes $7 Billion Share Sale at an $852 Billion Valuation

OpenAI completed a tender offer of roughly $7 billion in mid-August 2026, allowing employees to sell shares at a valuation of about $852 billion. The transaction was widely reported as preparation for a potential initial public offering, which would be the largest technology listing in history. For African founders, the relevance is comparative rather than direct: valuations at the frontier set the multiples against which every AI company is benchmarked, including those raising in Lagos, Nairobi and Accra.

OpenAI Completes $7 Billion Share Sale at an $852 Billion Valuation

DeepSeek-V4 API New Pricing

Model		Input (cache hit)	Input (cache miss)	Output
DeepSeek-V4-Flash	Off-Peak	$ 0.007	$ 0.22	$ 0.66
	Peak hours	$ 0.014	$ 0.44	$ 1.32
DeepSeek-V4-Pro	Off-Peak	$ 0.022	$ 0.66	$ 1.98
	Peak hours	$ 0.044	$ 1.32	$ 3.96

Peak Hours: 01:00–04:00 and 06:00–10:00 UTC (all other hours are off-peak)

Effective from: 16:00, August 16, 2026 (UTC)

DeepSeek moved DeepSeek-V4-Pro out of preview on 13 August 2026, emphasising agentic capability for multi-step workflows, a one-million-token context window and outputs of up to 384,000 tokens. It simultaneously raised prices sharply: from 16 August, peak-hour output pricing rises to $3.96 per million tokens from $0.87, with off-peak rates at half the peak price. Anthropic released Claude Opus 5 on 24 July 2026, reported as smaller than its predecessor while outperforming it on several benchmarks.

Meta has meanwhile moved further into agentic coding with Muse Code, a terminal-based coding agent powered by Muse Spark 1.2 and currently in beta, built to plan changes across a codebase, write and debug code, run multiple sub-agents in parallel and validate its own output across long-running tasks. The direction of travel is consistent: coding models are shifting from completing individual lines towards planning and coordinating substantial parts of the development process.

The pricing move matters more than the benchmark scores. Low-cost Chinese models have been the default economic choice for many African teams building on hosted APIs; a four-fold increase in peak pricing materially changes the build-versus-buy calculation and strengthens the argument — heard repeatedly at the Indaba — for smaller, locally fine-tuned models that can run on modest infrastructure.

Paper: Full Fine-Tuning vs. Parameter-Efficient Adaptation for Low-Resource African ASR: A Controlled Study with Whisper-Small

Authors: Sukairaj Hafiz Imam, Muhammad Yahuza Bello, Hadiza Ali Umar, Tadesse Destaw Belay, Idris Abdulmumin, Seid Muhie Yimam, Shamsuddeen Hassan Muhammad

Venue: Proceedings of the 7th Workshop on African Natural Language Processing (AfricaNLP 2026), held alongside EACL 2026, Rabat, Morocco.

Building a speech recognition system for Nigerian languages has normally meant retraining an entire large model — an expensive exercise requiring computing power most Nigerian institutions simply do not have. This study, led from Bayero University Kano, asks whether a far cheaper approach works just as well.

Using a ten-hour slice of the NaijaVoices dataset covering Hausa, Yorùbá and Igbo, the team compared full retraining of OpenAI's Whisper-Small model against "parameter-efficient" methods that adjust only a tiny fraction of it. One such method, DoRA, matched full retraining almost exactly — a word error rate of 22.0 per cent against 22.1 per cent — while updating around four million parameters instead of 240 million, roughly a sixtieth of the work. The remaining differences fell within normal run-to-run variation.

The implication is practical and immediate: Nigerian universities and startups can build usable Hausa, Yorùbá and Igbo voice systems on modest hardware. That removes one of the more stubborn cost barriers to local-language voice services in health, agriculture and government call centres.

Paper: ÒWE-Voice: An Evaluation of Monolingual and Multilingual ASR Models Using a Yoruba Proverb Speech Dataset

Authors: Daud Abolade (Masakhane; NITHUB, University of Lagos; NKANDA)

Venue: Proceedings of the 7th Workshop on African Natural Language Processing (AfricaNLP 2026), held alongside EACL 2026, Rabat, Morocco.

Yorùbá proverbs, òwe, compress a great deal of cultural meaning into a few heavily tonal words. That makes them an unusually demanding test for speech recognition, and a revealing one.

The author built a six-hour dataset of 1,250 recorded Yorùbá proverbs, drawing on the existing ÒWE-Yor corpus of 4,930 proverbs plus 70 newly collected in the field in Lagos and Ogun State. Twelve native-speaker voice talents, male and female, recorded in a controlled studio. Two existing systems were then tested on unseen proverbs. A Yorùbá-specific model built on Whisper Small returned a word error rate of 72.45 per cent and a tone error rate of 27.83 per cent; Meta's 1,162-language MMS model performed far worse, at 95.42 per cent and 66.75 per cent.

Neither result is good, and that is the finding. General-purpose global models cannot handle culturally dense Nigerian speech, and even locally built models still struggle with tone. For anyone commissioning Yorùbá voice products, the paper is a caution against assuming a multilingual model will do. The dataset also stands on its own as a preservation asset for Yorùbá oral heritage.

Home-grown Research with Global Recognition

Paper: A Multimodal Dataset for Automating Language Vitality and Endangerment Assessment in South-South Nigeria
Authors: Moses Ekpenyong (University of Uyo) and 30 co-authors across the University of Calabar, Delta State University, University of Benin, the National Institute for Nigerian Languages, Arthur Jarvis University and Nigeria Maritime University
Venue: Scientific Data (Nature Portfolio), Volume 12, Article 1102.

Nigeria has hundreds of languages, but until now there has been no reliable household-level evidence on which of them are actually dying. This consortium of Nigerian universities set out to build it.
The team ran a structured survey across six South-South states — Akwa Ibom, Bayelsa, Cross River, Delta, Edo and Rivers — covering more than 48 languages, and collected 543 validated household responses between July 2023 and April 2024. Alongside the survey they recorded audio of 108 Swadesh-list words per language, transcribed with gloss and tone marking. The design adapts UNESCO's Language Vitality and Endangerment framework down to household level, disaggregated by age and gender, so it can pinpoint exactly where parents have stopped passing a language on to their children.

The result is two assets at once. Policymakers at the Ministry of Education, the National Institute for Nigerian Languages and state governments gain an evidence base for targeting language-preservation spending. And AI builders gain the audio and transcription foundation that any future speech technology for these minority languages will require — published in one of the most respected data journals in the world.

Also worth watching: Nigerian work presented at Deep Learning Indaba 2026 in Lagos includes "Eng-PidginEdu: A Large-Scale Educational Translation Dataset for Nigerian Pidgin through Glossary-Augmentation" and "NaijaAgro-Chat: A Multilingual, Retrieval-Augmented Conversational Assistant for Nigerian Smallholder Farmers", together with an Enugu-dialect Igbo multimodal dataset. At the time of writing the Indaba had published titles and presenters but not abstracts or full papers, so these are listed here as signposts rather than featured summaries.

Browse the full poster listing: Deep Learning Indaba 2026 accepted posters

Opportunities and Events

An overview of upcoming events, available funding, proposal invitations, and other timely opportunities shared within the Community.

Sahara CodeSwitch Africa Challenge

[Sahara CodeSwitch Africa Challenge]

Deadline: 15 September 2026 (registration and submissions)

Launched at Deep Learning Indaba 2026 by the Nigerian-founded voice AI company Intron, this challenge asks builders to develop a voice AI application that performs a real task using code-switched African audio — the everyday mixing of English with Yorùbá, Hausa, Igbo or Pidgin that defeats most commercial speech systems. Entrants must benchmark at least three speech models, including Intron's Sahara API and two alternatives.

There is a $10,000 cash prize pool across five tracks: Health; Fintech, Telco and Customer Experience; Legal and Public Services; Agriculture and Education; and Other High-Impact Use Cases. It is open to builders across Africa and the diaspora — developers, researchers, students, startups, NGOs and companies — entering individually or in teams of two to five. Submissions require a problem description, a working prototype video, code and documentation, benchmark results and a responsible-AI statement covering privacy and consent. Winners are announced on 1 October 2026. Few opportunities this month are a better fit for Nigerian speech and language teams.

BUILD Conference 2026 — Call for Abstracts

[BUILD Conference 2026 – Call for Abstracts](#)
Deadline: 15 September 2026

Building Africa's Shared Compute and AI Infrastructure

The Nigeria AI Collective is convening BUILD Conference 2026, a conference focused on the infrastructure required to enable Africa's AI future — from data centres and GPU clusters to sovereign cloud platforms, energy systems, connectivity, data infrastructure and the governance frameworks that support them.

Researchers, academics, practitioners, doctoral researchers and emerging scholars are invited to contribute work addressing Africa's shared compute and AI infrastructure challenges. Submissions may take the form of extended abstracts, policy briefs, research posters, or case studies, with themes spanning infrastructure, economics, governance and ethics, skills, data, and innovation.

The conference will take place on 21–22 October 2026 in Abuja, Nigeria.
Who can apply: Researchers, academics, practitioners, doctoral researchers and emerging scholars
Focus: Shared compute, AI infrastructure, data centres, GPU/HPC infrastructure, sovereign cloud, energy, connectivity, data governance, financing, AI skills, governance and AI innovation.
This is particularly relevant to researchers and practitioners working on the infrastructure foundations of responsible and sovereign AI development in Africa.

Opportunities and Events

AI for Good — Global Youth AI Future Innovation Competition 2026

AI for Good — Global Youth AI Future Innovation Competition 2026

Deadline: **15 September 2026**

Organised by the UNU Global AI Network under United Nations University, with UNU Macau and Venture Cup China, this competition runs under the theme “AI and Education: AI Transforming the Educational Paradigm and Enhancing AI Literacy”, anchored on Sustainable Development Goal 4 with links to SDGs 5, 9, 10, 16 and 17.

There are three tracks — AI for Education, AI for Social Innovation, and AI for Less Developed Countries — the last of which is directly aimed at teams building in contexts such as Nigeria’s. Any company, group or individual worldwide may enter; projects should be at technology readiness level 6 or above, enterprises must be under ten years old, and submissions are in English. There is no entry fee. Judging runs from 16 to 30 September, semi-finals from 1 to 15 October, and the global final takes place in Macau on 26 November 2026, with complimentary accommodation and travel allowances of up to $1,000 per team available to finalists on a limited basis.

SGCI Multilateral Research Call — Advancing Africa’s STI Priorities (STISA-2034)

Opportunities and Events

[SGCI Multilateral Research Call — Advancing Africa's STI Priorities (STISA-2034)]

Deadline: 25 September 2026, 23:59 EDT (Expressions of Interest)

This is the largest research funding opportunity in this edition: $12 million in grants for African-led research consortia, administered by the Science Granting Councils Initiative with African science granting councils, Norway, the UK Foreign, Commonwealth and Development Office, the Wellcome Trust and Canada's IDRC. Artificial Intelligence and Digital Technologies is one of five priority themes, alongside Health, Agriculture, Energy and Environment. Nigeria is among the 20 eligible African countries. Consortia must include a minimum of three institutions, with up to five co-applicant institutions drawn from five different countries and spanning at least three SGCI member states; projects may run for up to 36 months. The portal offers an optional matchmaking service to help researchers form partnerships before applying. This one is built for Nigerian universities and research institutes rather than individual applicants — and the consortium requirement means preparation should start now, not in September.

Advanced Human Rights Course: AI and Human Rights in Africa

[Advanced Human Rights Course: AI and Human Rights in Africa]

Deadline: 30 September 2026 (course runs 12–16 October 2026, online)

A five-day intensive online short course from the Global Center on AI Governance in partnership with the Centre for Human Rights at the University of Pretoria, examining where AI intersects with human rights in Africa — privacy, democracy, gender, health, children's rights and employment, and what rights-centred AI governance looks like in practice.

It is aimed at a deliberately mixed cohort from across the continent: civil society, policymakers, academics, grassroots advocates and the private sector. The fee is $150, with a scholarship route available on submission of a financial-need statement. Applicants should submit a CV of no more than three pages, a letter of recommendation and a motivation letter, and should expect around seven hours of sessions per day. Certificates are awarded to participants who attend all sessions and complete daily written reflections. Places are limited.

Upcoming Events

An overview of upcoming events, available funding, proposal invitations, and other timely opportunities shared within the Community.

1. MCP Developers Summit Nairobi

Date: 19–20 November 2026 (call for proposals closes 31 August 2026)
Location: Nairobi, Kenya (In-person)

A developer-focused summit on the Model Context Protocol as it moves from experimentation into complex agentic and enterprise environments, presented by the Agentic AI Foundation with Gates Foundation sponsorship, and promoted within the Nigerian ecosystem by Data Science Nigeria. The open call for proposals covers six areas: MCP protocol in depth; building with MCP; security, identity and trust; enterprise adoption and integration; agent architecture and orchestration; and ecosystem, registries and platform infrastructure. Proposals are invited for 25-minute presentations, 25-minute panels and 60-minute workshops, first-time speakers are explicitly encouraged, and accepted speakers receive a complimentary summit pass. Nigerian engineers building agentic systems should note the 31 August proposal deadline — it falls in the week this digest publishes.

2. Pan African AI and Innovation Summit 2026

Pan African AI and Innovation Summit 2026
Date: 22–23 September 2026
Location: Kempinski Hotel Gold Coast City, Accra, Ghana (In-person)

The second Accra edition of this pan-African summit, convened with Ghana's Ministry of Communication, Digital Technology and Innovations and Ministry of Youth Development and Empowerment. The agenda centres on youth-focused digital innovation, nationwide AI literacy, data science training and start-up incubation. Partners include the Estonian Business Angels Network, whose investors are attending to look at African start-ups, the University of Ghana Digital Youth Village and Brandeis University. Announced speakers include Smart Africa Director General Lacina Koné. For Nigerian founders, it is the nearest major pan-African AI summit with an explicit investor pipeline attached.

Upcoming Events

3. AI Expo Africa 2026

AI Expo Africa 2026
Date: 28-29 October 2026
Location:Sandton Convention Centre, Johannesburg, South Africa (In-person)

Now in its ninth year, AI Expo Africa is the continent's largest enterprise AI and intelligent automation trade show, expecting more than 3,500 delegates of whom over 80 per cent are decision-makers. The two-day programme covers a 10,000 square-foot exhibition hall with 100-plus vendors, four speaking tracks totalling 52 talks and panels, eight CPD-accredited workshops, two plenary keynotes and eight private CxO round tables.

Dedicated zones include a Women in AI Pavilion, a Startup Zone with investor matchmaking, an R&D Zone and a Robot and Drone Zone. This is the most commercially oriented AI event in Africa and the most direct route for Nigerian AI vendors seeking enterprise buyers.

4. Moonshot by TechCabal 2026

Moonshot by TechCabal 2026
Date: 28-29 October 2026
Location: National Theatre, Lagos, Nigeria (In-person)

The fourth edition of TechCabal's flagship pan-African technology conference, themed "Courage and Conviction: Building for a New World". Nine tracks span the Future of Commerce, Creative Economy, Emerging Tech and AI, Government, Policy and Regulation, the FUEL investor conference, a Startup Festival, Clean and Climate Tech, Big Tech and Enterprise, and the Future of Money. The 2025 edition drew 6,000 attendees from 39 countries, and confirmed participants for 2026 include OpenAI Africa, Flutterwave and Nigeria's Securities and Exchange Commission. The largest Nigeria-based technology conference with a dedicated AI track.

5. Africa Tech Festival 2026 (incorporating AfricaCom and AfricaTech)

Africa Tech Festival 2026 (incorporating AfricaCom and AfricaTech)
Date: 17–19 November 2026
Location: Cape Town International Convention Centre, Cape Town, South Africa (In-person)

The 29th edition of the continent's longest-running major technology festival, organised by Informa Connect and built on six pillars: Telecoms and Connectivity, Data Centres, AI, Cybersecurity, Startups and Digital Transformation. A dedicated AI Summit Cape Town track runs alongside AfricaCom and AfricaTech, with masterclasses, a Next Gen Talent programme, Leadership Council sessions, an awards ceremony and a startup showcase. Sponsors include Microsoft, Ericsson and Orange Middle East and Africa. If your interest is where African data-centre and AI infrastructure investment decisions actually get made, this is the room.

6. NeurIPS 2026

NeurIPS 2026
Date: 6–12 December 2026 (Sydney); satellite events 9–13 December 2026
Location: Sydney, Australia, with satellite events in Paris, France and Atlanta, Georgia

The 40th Conference on Neural Information Processing Systems remains the world's premier machine learning research venue. Of particular note for Nigerian researchers: the 2026 edition runs a multi-track format across three geographies expressly to widen global participation, and the Paris satellite from 9 to 13 December is materially easier and cheaper to reach from Lagos or Abuja than Sydney. Author notifications for accepted papers are due on 24 September 2026. Community members planning ahead should follow registration and financial-aid announcements on the official site

Dr Olubayo Adekanmbi
(Founder and Chief Executive, Data Science Nigeria)

Closing remarks, Deep Learning Indaba 2026, Pan-Atlantic University, Lagos, August 2026.

Naming five "diseases" he argued are holding back Africa's AI ecosystem — Attendiasis, Sponsoriasis, Posteriosis, Communitydemia and Profilitis — he challenged researchers and builders to move past superficial wins and commit properly to building sovereign intelligence for the continent, closing with a single charge: "Don't stop until you are proud!"

Read more: EqualyzAI on LinkedIn

Professor Enase Okonedo
(Vice-Chancellor, Pan-Atlantic University)

On Pan-Atlantic University hosting Deep Learning Indaba 2026, July 2026.

"Pan-Atlantic University is honoured to host the 2026 Deep Learning Indaba and to welcome Africa's vibrant artificial intelligence and machine learning community to our campus."

Read more: Brand Times

The Deep Learning Indaba 2026 General Chairs
Aisha Alaagib, Albert Njoroge Kahira and Chinazo Anebelundu (Data Science Nigeria)

On bringing Africa's flagship machine learning gathering to Nigeria, July 2026.

"The Indaba is a collective promise that African talent will not stand at the periphery of global AI, but at the centre of its creation and its future." They added: "Bringing the Indaba to Nigeria gives this moment even greater meaning. Nigeria represents scale, imagination, and a fearless belief in what is possible."

Read more: Brand Times

Thought Leadership

Dr. Bosun Tijani
(Minister of Communications, Innovation and Digital Economy, Nigeria)

Ahead of GITEX Nigeria 2026, August 2026.
"Building on the momentum forged through the implementation of Project BRIDGE, our national blueprint for expanding digital infrastructure and connecting communities across Nigeria, our aspiration ahead of this year's edition is clear: to solidify the foundations Africa needs for digital sovereignty, technological self-determination, and a globally competitive AI-powered economy."

Read more: Vanguard

President Paul Kagame
(President of the Republic of Rwanda)

Remarks at the AI for Good Global Summit, Geneva, 8 July 2026.
"In Africa, we are no longer satisfied to be passive consumers of technology. We want to build and deploy it at scale." He also urged that "we must be intentional about designing, funding and governing A.I. so that it can reach its full potential."

Read more: Office of the President of Rwanda

Doreen Bogdan-Martin
(Secretary-General, International Telecommunication Union)

At the African Telecommunications Union Conference of Plenipotentiaries, Abuja, July 2026.

"Africa will not simply participate in the digital future. Africa will help shape it — not only as a consumer of technology, but as a creator, an innovator, a standard setter and a trusted global partner."

Read more: TechCabal

Thought Leadership

Dr Tobi Olatunji
(Founder and Chief Executive, Intron)

On launching the Sahara CodeSwitch Africa Challenge at Deep Learning Indaba 2026, Lagos, 4 August 2026.

“Language mixing remains one of the most persistent failure points for African clients deploying voice AI.”

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